Press & Education under Colonial Rule

Instruments of rule that Indians turned into instruments of nationalism

2 Mains PYQs 2023 · 2026 · both 10M
Silent for a decade, now **rising** · Macaulay 2026 · Gandhi–Tagore 2023 · **~18 Prelims:** founders, Wood's clauses, Lytton/Ripon

THE ANSWER SPINE 1 **Built for rule** → 2 **Control swings with fear** → 3 **Macaulay's class** → 4 **Filtration to mass schooling — on paper** → 5 **Indians appropriate both** → **Qualify: a narrow elite**

① PRESS LAWS — TIGHTEN & RELAX

Prelims: VPA ×2 Lytton made · Ripon repealed

Tighten	Relax
1799 Wellesley — censorship (French fear) **1823** John Adam — licensing; Mirat-ul-Akbar shut **1857** Canning — Licensing Act **1878** Lytton — **Vernacular Press Act**: vernacular only, bonds, no appeal **1908** Minto — Incitement Act; Tilak 6 yrs **1910** Press Act — security deposits **1931** Emergency Powers Act **1939–45** DIR, pre-censorship	**1835** Metcalfe — Press Act; "liberator of the press" **1867** Registration Act (regulate; replaced 2023) **1882** Ripon — VPA repealed **1921** Sapru Committee — 1908 & 1910 Acts repealed **Start:** Hicky's *Bengal Gazette* 1780 (seized 1782)

Line: every major press law followed a nationalist advance.

Trap: VPA is **Lytton**, not Curzon. *Amrita Bazar Patrika* went English overnight to escape it.

② THE INDIAN PRESS & ITS ROLE

Prelims: Al-Hilal, Som Prakash, Vital-Vidhvansak, Indian Sociologist

Rammohun Samvad Kaumudi 1821, Mirat-ul-Akbar 1822 · **Bombay Samachar** 1822 · **Hindoo Patriot** 1853 (indigo) · **Som Prakash** Vidyasagar · **Amrita Bazar Patrika** 1868 · **The Hindu** 1878 & Swadesamitran (G. Subramania Iyer) · **Bengalee** Surendranath · **Kesari/Mahratta** 1881 Tilak · **Tribune** 1881 · **Vital-Vidhvansak** 1888 Walangkar · **Bande Mataram**, Yugantar · **Indian Sociologist** Krishna Varma · **Al-Hilal** 1912 Azad · **Young India, Navajivan, Harijan** Gandhi · **Mook Nayak** Ambedkar · **Vanguard** M. N. Roy

Role: political education (drain, council debates) · criticism (famine, Ilbert Bill) · mobilisation (Swadeshi → Gandhian weeklies) · **reach beyond literacy** — one copy read aloud to many.

Press as resistance: Tilak jailed 1897 and 1908 (Mandalay, 6 yrs) — Bombay mill workers struck · Gandhi ran his campaigns through his weeklies · campaigns on famine and the Ilbert Bill.

15-mark frame: educate → criticise → mobilise → resist repression → limits. Close: every press law followed a nationalist advance.

Limits: small, urban, English–vernacular split; communal press grew too.

The Dual-Effect Framework

Read across a row for the paradox — the tracker's two frameworks in one grid

	PRESS	EDUCATION
Rule	Licensing (1823, 1867); sedition watch; repression in crisis (1878, 1908–10, 1931)	Clerks and interpreters (Macaulay 1835); English = language of rule; university control (1904)
Nationalism	Educated a public; popularised the drain; organised Swadeshi to Quit India	Liberal ideas; common English across regions; lawyers, journalists, teachers who led Congress
Appropriation	Kesari, Amrita Bazar, Young India, Harijan; reading rooms	Hindu College 1817; Deccan Ed. Society 1884; DAV 1886; Aligarh 1875; national schools 1906, 1920
Limits	Small circulation; deposits and confiscation	Narrow upper-caste urban base; only ~18% literate in 1951

THE PARADOX: built to produce subordinates, they produced the critics who ended the Raj

COUNTER-CASES & QUALIFICATIONS — WRITE ONE

- **CONTROL** Gauri Viswanathan 1989: English literature taught as **moral control**
- **KNOWLEDGE** Bernard Cohn 1996: colonial knowledge as a **tool of rule**
- **COMMUNAL** The press that built nationalism also built **communal politics**
- **GANDHI** *Hind Swaraj* 1909: English education **enslaves** millions
- **MASSES** Filtration failed: mass literacy barely moved till 1947

③ COMPANY ERA & MACAULAY'S MINUTE

2026 · 10M "administration and education"

Founders: Calcutta Madrasa 1781 **Warren Hastings** · Asiatic Society 1784 **William Jones** · Sanskrit College Benaras 1791 **Jonathan Duncan** · Fort William 1800 **Richard Wellesley** (train British civilians) · Charter Act 1813: **Rs 1 lakh** · Hindu College 1817 (Hare, Rammohun).

Orientalists Prinsep, Wilson vs **Anglicists** Macaulay, Trevelyan; Rammohun's 1823 letter for Western science.

Minute, 2 Feb 1835: "a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect" · "a single shelf of a good European library…". Bentinck's resolution, 7 Mar 1835 · **downward filtration**.

Administration: English the language of rule; Persian out of courts 1837; Hardinge 1844 prefers English-educated. **Education:** English colleges; vernacular starved. **Unintended:** the interpreters became nationalists.

2026 answer frame (150 w): settles Orientalist–Anglicist → **administration** (English rule, 1837 courts, 1844 jobs) → **education** (English colleges, filtration, vernacular starved) → **unintended** nationalist class → limit: narrow elite.

Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj* 1909: to give millions a knowledge of English is to enslave them.

④ POLICY LADDER, 1854–1944

Prelims: Wood ×3, chronologies ×2 Gokhale's Bill 1998

- **Wood 1854** — "Magna Carta": state duty for mass education; **vernacular primary, English higher**; grants-in-aid; universities 1857 (Calcutta, Bombay, Madras); women's education
- **Hunter 1882** — primary to local boards
- **Raleigh 1902 → Universities Act 1904** (Curzon) — control
- **Gokhale's Bill 1911** defeated (1912) · **1913 Resolution**
- **Sadler 1917–19** — 12-yr school, 3-yr degree
- **Montford 1919** — education to Indian ministers
- **Hartog 1929** — wastage and stagnation
- **Sargent 1944** — free compulsory 6–14; 40-year plan

Traps: Wood did **not** want English at all levels · Hunter **Commission** 1882 ≠ Hunter **Committee** 1919.

⑤ NATIONAL EDUCATION · GANDHI vs TAGORE

2023 · 10M Prelims 2019: NCE in Swadeshi

Indian institutions: Aligarh 1875 · Deccan Ed. Society 1884 · DAV 1886 · BHU 1916 · **Swadeshi:** National Council of Education 1906, Bengal National College (Aurobindo) · **NCM:** Gujarat Vidyapith 1920, Jamia 1920, Kashi Vidyapith 1921.

	Gandhi	Tagore
Aim	Character, self-reliance; head-heart-hand	Freedom of mind, creativity, nature
Method	Craft; self-supporting — **Wardha 1937**	Arts, open air — **Santiniketan 1901, Visva-Bharati 1921**
Nation	Mass, anti-colonial; school boycott 1920	Critic of nationalism (1917); internationalist
Clash	"The Call of Truth" (1921) vs "The Great Sentinel" (1921)	

Line: Gandhi sought a free nation, Tagore a free mind. **Common ground:** mother tongue, anti-rote, village.

Wardha 1937: Zakir Hussain Committee · 7 years free and compulsory · mother tongue · craft-centred, self-supporting · stalled 1939 when ministries resigned. **Tagore:** Sriniketan 1922 for rural reconstruction.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE The British built a press regime and a school system to govern cheaply — clerks, interpreters, a watched public. Control tightened after every crisis; education moved from Macaulay's filtration to Wood's mass schooling on paper but never in money. Indians turned both into the engines of nationalism. *The qualification: the class they created was narrow, urban and upper-caste, and the masses stayed outside — only 18% literate at independence.*